

CHAPTER 6 — Walk Normally

Elias left the booth with the loose irritation of a man returning to a badly parked car.

Zoe stood half a second later.

Not because she felt ready.

Because he had.

The backpack sat high across both shoulders. Her legs felt separate from the rest of her body, light and unreliable, as though the three minutes in the locked toilet had removed something from them.

Elias moved towards the entrance.

Zoe took position on his left.

The restaurant continued around them.

A server emerged from the kitchen carrying three plates and forced Elias to alter his path without changing speed. Zoe followed the movement late and nearly struck the corner of a table.

Her hip touched the wood.

A fork rattled against a plate.

The sound felt enormous.

Nobody outside reacted.

A little boy stepped backwards from the drinks machine holding a cup with no lid. Elias slowed enough to prevent a collision but did not stop. The child's mother caught his shoulder and apologised.

Elias nodded.

Ordinary interruption.

Ordinary response.

Zoe kept moving.

At the shop entrance, two lorry drivers blocked half the route while discussing lane closures. Elias passed between one of them and a display of travel sweets. Zoe had to turn slightly to avoid the man's elbow.

For one moment, she lost sight of the automatic doors.

Panic rose hard enough to shorten her breath.

Then Elias appeared again in front of her.

Same pace.

Same distance.

He had not looked back.

He had trusted her to remain there.

The doors opened.

Heat struck them.

Sunlight flattened the car park and erased the softer reflections that had allowed Zoe to watch from inside. Diesel fumes hung beneath the petrol-station canopy. A coach engine idled near the far kerb. Somewhere behind the building, glass bottles emptied into a recycling bin.

The hatchback stood seventy feet away.

It looked smaller than it had when they entered.

Too far.

Elias stepped onto the pavement.

Zoe matched him.

Not quickly.

Not slowly.

Normal.

The first man waited beside the entrance awning.

He did not block them.

His hands remained empty.

His eyes passed over Elias and settled on Zoe for less than a second.

That was enough.

She knew the look.

Not anger.

Inventory.

Elias moved between them without appearing to.

The man let them pass.

Twenty feet.

The family beside the hatchback had finished loading their car. The two children kicked the football between the open doors while their mother tried to fasten a seat belt around the younger one.

The ball escaped.

It rolled across Zoe's path.

Her body wanted to stop.

Elias continued.

Zoe stepped over it.

One of the children ran after the ball and called an apology. Zoe did not answer.

Thirty feet.

The second man stood near a vending machine beside the path to the car park. He held a bottle of water and watched the blank screen of his phone.

When Elias and Zoe reached his position, he lifted the bottle.

Not drinking.

A signal.

Zoe saw movement beyond the parked vehicles.

A door opened near the dark saloon.

Someone remained behind it.

Forty feet.

Her mouth had gone dry again.

The restaurant door opened behind them.

Footsteps crossed the pavement.

Zoe's shoulders tightened.

"Don't," Elias murmured.

She had not realised her head had begun to turn.

The word was quiet enough that no one else could use it.

Fifty feet.

The tall man in the black jacket stepped out from between two coaches.

Zoe recognised him before his face entered full sunlight.

The same patient posture.

The same hands hanging loosely at his sides.

The same expression he had worn in Cain's house while watching children fall silent around him.

She had seen him in doorways, corridors and the room with too many chairs. Adults lowered their voices when he arrived. One handler had called him sir. Another had started explaining a mistake before he asked a question.

Lieutenant was not a rank Zoe had been told.

It was the word her mind had given the authority everyone else displayed around him.

Her stride shortened.

Elias adjusted his own pace by the same fraction without looking at her.

The lieutenant watched them approach.

His face remained unreadable until his eyes settled properly on Elias.

Then something changed.

Not much.

A slight loss of colour around the mouth.

The right hand moving away from his jacket pocket rather than towards it.

Confirmation arriving before preparation.

“Elias.”

The voice crossed the car park without being raised.

Zoe’s step stopped for less than a second.

Elias continued.

“Don’t.”

She forced her left foot forward.

The lieutenant did not follow.

That frightened her more than pursuit would have.

He called again.

“Elias.”

No mockery.

No threat.

Only the careful disbelief of a man confirming that a story had acquired a face.

Elias’s shoulders remained loose.

Inside him, an older room opened.

Fluorescent light.

Concrete.

Someone speaking the same name from behind a loading-bay pillar.

The smell of hot metal.

A younger voice saying, Left side.

Then nothing he intended to remember in a service-station car park.

He gave the memory no space beyond identification.

Past.

Not now.

The hatchback waited twenty feet ahead.

One of Cain's men moved from behind a family car.

He was not yet intercepting.

Only reducing the angle towards the driver's door.

Elias changed their line by half a metre.

Zoe followed.

The adjustment placed the bonnet of a parked delivery van between them and the man.

Ten feet.

The hatchback unlocked with a soft mechanical click.

"Back seat," Elias said.

Zoe opened the rear door.

The backpack caught against the frame.

For one terrible second, the strap held her outside.

She twisted.

The fabric released.

She climbed in and pulled the door closed.

Elias reached the driver's side.

The man beyond the delivery van changed direction.

No longer pretending.

Elias entered the car and locked the central doors.

Zoe tested her handle.

It still opened from inside.

Promise maintained under pressure.

The lieutenant called once more.

"Elias."

He stood twenty feet behind them.

Black jacket despite the heat.

Hands visible.

No movement towards the car.

Zoe looked at him through the rear window.

He was not watching her now.

Only Elias.

The other men watched the lieutenant, waiting for the instruction his body refused to provide.

Elias started the engine.

The hatchback coughed.

Once.

Twice.

The man near the delivery van came closer.

“Come on,” Elias said.

The engine caught.

He selected reverse.

A white estate car entered the lane behind them and stopped to allow a pedestrian across. The temporary obstruction closed the easiest route out.

Elias did not force it.

He waited.

The approaching man reached the rear quarter of the hatchback.

His hand touched the roof.

Zoe moved away from the door.

Elias lowered the driver’s window by two inches.

The man bent towards it.

“Switch it off.”

Elias looked at him.

The man saw whatever the lieutenant had recognised.

His hand left the roof.

The white estate moved.

Elias reversed.

The approaching man stepped back quickly to protect his feet.

The hatchback turned out of the space.

Across the car park, one of Cain’s men ran towards the dark saloon.

Another moved towards a black four-by-four hidden behind the coaches.

Elias selected first gear.

“Hold on.”

Zoe braced one hand against the seat and the other against the backpack.

The hatchback rolled forward.

Not fast.

Speed before the first turn would only reduce control.

They passed the family car.

The younger child had finally been fastened into the seat. His mother shut the door and looked towards the men moving across the car park.

Civilian attention spread.

A coach driver stopped smoking.

The lorry drivers near the entrance turned towards the dark saloon.

Cain’s people were becoming visible.

That limited them.

The lieutenant remained still.

He raised a phone to his ear.

Zoe watched him shrink in the rear window.

“He knows you,” she said.

Elias checked the mirror.

“He recognised something.”

“That is the same.”

“No.”

The dark saloon moved from its space.

Its rear wheel completed one full rotation.

Then collapsed towards the rim.

The driver braked.

A second tyre on the same side folded under the weight of the car.

The vehicle stopped diagonally across two bays.

The black four-by-four started after it.

It travelled ten feet before the front left corner dropped sharply. The driver corrected too hard and struck a low concrete divider.

Not a crash.

Enough to stop.

Cain's men spread around both vehicles, looking down at the tyres and then across the car park towards Elias.

Understanding arrived too late to be useful.

Zoe turned towards the front.

"What did you do?"

"Delayed them."

"How?"

"Later."

"They were watching you."

"They were watching the restaurant."

"You walked past their cars."

"Yes."

"In three minutes."

"Yes."

"That is impossible."

"It was enough time."

Elias crossed the service-area exit lane.

A barrier arm rose slowly ahead of them.

The payment machine flashed green for a vehicle leaving the fuel station and began descending again.

Elias accelerated.

The hatchback passed beneath it before the arm reached halfway.

A horn sounded behind them.

He joined the slip road.

In the rear-view mirror, the service area began to disappear behind trees.

The lieutenant remained visible for one final second beside the crippled saloon.

Phone against his ear.

Face turned towards the departing hatchback.

He did not look angry.

He looked like a man about to report that something believed dead had just driven away.